Proof Found: A Space Rock Hit the North Sea Long Ago

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About 43 to 46 million years ago, an **asteroid** crashed into the area where the North Sea is now. It made a giant wave, called a **tsunami**, more than 100 meters (330 feet) tall. Now scientists say they have proof.

The crash left a hole called the Silverpit **Crater**. It is hidden about 700 meters under the seafloor, near the coast of England.

Scientists found the **crater** in 2002. But some thought salt moving underground or **volcanoes** made it instead.

A team led by Dr. Uisdean Nicholson used sound waves to see under the rock. They also studied rock bits from a nearby oil well.

They found tiny "shocked" **crystals**. Only a huge crash can make **crystals** like these. "We were exceptionally lucky to find these," Nicholson said.

Now Silverpit is one of the few proven **asteroid craters** on Earth.

Word Treasure

asteroid -- An asteroid is a big space rock that travels around the Sun.

tsunami -- A tsunami is a giant ocean wave.

crater -- A crater is a bowl-shaped hole made when something hits the ground hard.

crystals -- Crystals are solid pieces of minerals with a neat, repeating shape.

volcanoes -- Volcanoes are openings in the Earth where hot melted rock comes out.

Background you need

Long ago, space rocks sometimes crashed into Earth and left big holes called craters.

Many old craters are hidden under oceans or rock, so scientists need special tools to find and study them.

Only a huge crash can squeeze tiny crystals hard enough to change them, so those crystals are proof of a hit.

Break it down

WHO: Dr. Uisdean Nicholson and his team of scientists
WHAT: They proved an asteroid made the Silverpit Crater about 43 to 46 million years ago
WHERE: Under the North Sea, near the coast of England
WHY: Tiny shocked crystals that only a huge crash can make were found at the crater

Why it matters

Learning about old space rock crashes helps scientists understand how our planet has changed and stay ready for the future.

Test what you remember

1. What crashed into the North Sea area long ago?

- (A) A plane
- (B) A whale
- (C) A ship
- (D) An asteroid

2. How tall was the giant wave?

- (A) 5 meters
- (B) More than 100 meters
- (C) 10 centimeters
- (D) 1 meter

3. What is the crater called?

- (A) Silverpit Crater
- (B) Ocean Bowl
- (C) Big Hole
- (D) Moon Crater

4. When did scientists find the crater?

- (A) 1802
- (B) 2025
- (C) 2002
- (D) 1950

5. What tiny clue proved the crash?

- (A) Shocked crystals
- (B) Gold coins
- (C) Fish bones
- (D) Sea shells

6. What did scientists use to see under the rock?

- (A) Magnets
- (B) Flashlights
- (C) Sound waves
- (D) Mirrors

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: A 4: C 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Dr. Uisdean Nicholson: Said the team was exceptionally lucky to find the crystals.

2. Some earlier scientists: Thought salt moving underground or volcanoes made the crater.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):